

of selling – in mind. This doesn't mean banking a small fortune, but hoping to leap ahead somewhat, irrespective of what the tea leaves hold for you.

Mortgage broker Will Unkles agrees that a land purchase can be key for your future security:

You need to get a property that will appreciate in value, because simple supply and demand rules say there is no more land being created, so let's buy land because, as the population grows, land gets more scarce. And if it has direct access to the city, a buyer can keep their city job and still live in this property.

This idea connects to the adage of 'worst house in the best street' – your land will be comparable in value to others of a similar size in the suburb, even if the house itself is a bit of a dump. When you see a hovel sell for a fortune, it's the cost of the land that has caused the price escalation. Some Australians sell old family homes on substantial blocks to developers who have very deep pockets and volcanic bidding power at auction; developers love these sites because they can subdivide that big parcel to build units and townhouses.

How to find this kind of property

You need a train-line map for your capital city, pen and paper, and your deposit amount, be it ten or 20 per cent. This is your blueprint for where to buy and, frankly, it's unlikely to inspire and motivate you – the chances of these suburbs being your first choice is slim, but make peace with this and persist.

Find the suburb profile by logging on to domain.com.au/suburb-profile and plugging in the postcode for a snapshot of the median house price. (Median prices are updated four times a year, so over the length of your first home search, you will need to review your list several times.) Scribble the prices next to the train stations to identify the distance from the city you need to venture to afford a house on a standard block of land there. Run a red line through the 'end of the line', where your budget won't stretch beyond.

When you inspect these train-accessible properties, walk from the home to the station; is it an acceptable distance for your circumstances, and do